TEXT TYPE · B2 · THE LONG TASK (~400 WORDS)

# The essay

*Argue your position with evidence*

| Word count | Register | Title | Structure |
|---|---|---|---|
| **~400 words (360–440)** | **Formal** | **Required** | **5 paragraphs** |

## STRUCTURE AND LAYOUT

**Title** – clear and relevant – not necessarily catchy
**Introduction** – ~80 words – hook + state your opinion clearly
**Body paragraph 1** – ~80 words – content point 1
**Body paragraph 2** – ~80 words – content point 2
**Body paragraph 3** – ~80 words – content point 3
**Conclusion** – ~80 words – summarise + restate opinion in different words

## DO'S AND DON'TS

### DO

- Write in a formal style throughout
- Make your opinion clear from the introduction
- Start each paragraph with a topic sentence
- Argue mainly with general and hypothetical examples. A short personal example is fine, but not as your main evidence.
- Use formal linking words: However, Nevertheless, Moreover, Furthermore
- Vary sentence length – mix short and long
- Use complex grammar: passive voice, conditionals, relative clauses
- You may mention a counter-argument, but then show why it is weaker

### DON'T

- No contractions (don't, can't, it's)
- No colloquial or slang expressions
- No overly emotional language
- No personal story as your main evidence ("When I was 12...")
- No over-generalisation ("All politicians are liars.")
- No text that uses only simple linking words (and, but, because)
- No very short sentences one after another
- No statistics without context

## WEAKER VS. STRONGER

### WEAKER

*Social media has many advantages and disadvantages for young people today.*

### STRONGER

*For teenagers, the real cost of social media is a slowly shrinking attention span.*

**Why it matters.** A strong essay opens each paragraph with one clear point that you can argue for. The weak version mentions advantages and disadvantages but takes no position, so the examiner cannot follow your line of argument.

## KEY TIP

An essay wants the reader to think: it is formal and argues with facts and general examples. An article can be personal and speaks to the reader directly.

## MODEL TEXT

**The Hidden Cost of Fast Fashion** (~400 words · Formal register)

**The task.** Your class has been discussing fast fashion. Your teacher has asked you to write an essay on the topic.

In your essay you should:

- describe the impact of fast fashion on the environment
- discuss the working conditions in clothing factories
- evaluate the argument that cheap clothes help people with little money

Write around 400 words. The model follows the five-paragraph plan: introduction, one paragraph for each content point, conclusion.

Text-specific Content Language

Have you ever stopped to think about where your clothes actually come from?[1] The fashion industry has grown dramatically over the past two decades, and by the mid-2010s the average shopper was already buying around 60% more clothing than in 2000. In my opinion, the environmental and social damage caused by fast fashion far outweighs the benefit of cheap clothing.[2]

To begin with, the environmental impact of fast fashion is severe.[3] The production of cheap garments requires enormous amounts of water and energy, and releases toxic chemicals into rivers and soil. According to the United Nations Environment Programme[4], the fashion industry is responsible for an estimated 2 to 8 per cent of global greenhouse gas emissions, alongside a considerable share of industrial water pollution. Furthermore,[5] a large share of these garments is worn only a handful of times before ending up in landfill. In addition, synthetic fabrics such as polyester are made from fossil fuels[6] and shed tiny microplastics with every single wash. These particles flow into rivers and oceans, and have even been detected in human blood.

Equally alarming are the working conditions in the factories that produce these clothes. Workers in countries such as Bangladesh and Cambodia are often forced to work twelve-hour shifts for wages that barely cover basic living costs. The Rana Plaza factory collapse in 2013, which killed over 1,100 garment workers,[7] exposed the dangerous reality behind bargain-priced T-shirts. Despite[8] promises of reform, investigations continue to reveal unsafe conditions. Independent researchers have also uncovered widespread child labour and the violent suppression of trade unions. While shoppers in Europe enjoy an endless supply of cheap outfits[9], the people who actually make them are denied a safe workplace and a living wage.

Admittedly,[10] some argue that fast fashion helps people with little money to dress well. While this may be true to some extent,[11] it does not justify an industry built on exploitation and pollution. Affordable clothing can exist without disposable clothing. A number of clothing brands have shown that durable, fairly produced garments do not have to be expensive.

Taking these points into consideration,[12] it is clear that the true cost of fast fashion is paid by the workers and by the planet. If we genuinely want to address the climate crisis,[13] we must start by rethinking our relationship with the clothes we wear. Consumers can make a real difference by buying less and repairing what they already own[14].

## WHAT THE EXAMINER NOTICES IN THIS MODEL

The numbers match the marked passages in the model text.

1. **Rhetorical question hook**: *"Have you ever stopped to think about where your clothes actually come from?"*
2. **Thesis – opinion stated clearly**: *"In my opinion, the environmental and social damage caused by fast fashion far outweighs the benefit of cheap c..."*
3. **Topic sentence (Point)**: *"To begin with, the environmental impact of fast fashion is severe."*
4. **Evidence introducer**: *"According to the United Nations Environment Programme"*
5. **B2 linking word**: *"Furthermore,"*
6. **Evidence developed in detail**: *"synthetic fabrics such as polyester are made from fossil fuels"*
7. **Relative clause – adds detail elegantly**: *"which killed over 1,100 garment workers,"*

8. **Linking word (contrast)**: *“Despite”*
9. **Contrast carries the argument**: *“While shoppers in Europe enjoy an endless supply of cheap outfits”*
10. **Counter-argument acknowledged**: *“Admittedly,”*
11. **Counter-argument refuted**: *“While this may be true to some extent,”*
12. **Linking word for the conclusion**: *“Taking these points into consideration,”*
13. **Conditional – complex structure**: *“If we genuinely want to address the climate crisis,”*
14. **Concrete call to action**: *“buying less and repairing what they already own”*

## USEFUL PHRASES

### Giving your opinion (without overusing "I")

- It is widely believed that…
- One can argue that…
- Many people are convinced that…
- For many people,…
- It is often argued that…

### When you do use "I"

- In my opinion/view,…
- I am inclined to believe that…
- I (firmly) believe that…
- I am (not) convinced that…

### Adding arguments

- Furthermore,…
- Moreover,…
- In addition to this,…
- What is more,…
- Not only… but also…

### Introducing the other side

- One should, nevertheless, consider…
- The other side of the coin is that…
- On the other hand,…
- Admittedly,…

### Conclusions

- Taking these points into consideration,…
- All of this points to the conclusion that…
- On balance, we can safely say that…
- The arguments presented prove that…

**More online.** On the website this text type also has a second model text (“Should smartphones be banned in schools?”, ~400 words · formal) and a realistic borderline text with notes on where it loses marks: matura.bernhardgmeiner.com/essay/